

HCM Vendor Selection Checklist

15 questions for choosing the right HRIS partner, before the demos decide for you

1,953 words

Consideration + decision

15 evaluation questions

Weighted scorecard

5 FAQ Q&A

Article + FAQPage + HowTo schema



HCM Vendor Checklist:

15 Questions for Choosing the Right HRIS Partner



A defensible HCM decision tests each vendor against the same operating scenarios, risks, and ownership questions. Original Align HCM editorial image.

VENDOR AGNOSTIC • VENDOR EVALUATION

HCM Vendor Selection Checklist: 15 Questions for Choosing the Right HRIS Partner

Draft for editorial and design review • VIB12 • Consideration + decision • Article + FAQPage + HowTo schema

Definition. An HCM vendor selection checklist is a cross-functional set of requirements, scenarios, evidence requests, and scoring rules used to compare HR technology vendors against the same business needs. The best HCM system is not the one with the longest feature list or the smoothest demo. It is the one that fits how your workforce operates, can be implemented with the capacity you actually have, and can be owned responsibly after go-live.

In this guide, the right HRIS partner means the combined software, implementation, and support relationship the organization will depend on. Buyers should score each responsibility separately even when one company promises to provide all three.



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I have watched disciplined HCM evaluations turn into presentation contests. One vendor has a beautiful employee experience. Another shows an impressive dashboard. Every team leaves with a different favorite because nobody agreed on the decision before the demos.

The fix is a better decision model: define outcomes, document hard operating scenarios, bring the right people into the room, and require every vendor to prove the same things.

● Key takeaways

- ◇ Define business outcomes and decision rights before inviting vendors.
- ◇ Use real payroll, workforce, security, reporting, and integration scenarios in every demo.
- ◇ Score implementation effort, adoption, support, and long-term ownership alongside product capability.
- ◇ Compare total cost across the full operating model, rather than subscription price alone.
- ◇ Make vendors identify assumptions, exclusions, dependencies, and customer responsibilities in writing.
- ◇ Right-size the platform to the organization rather than buying for a hypothetical future.

What should happen before HCM vendor demos?

Complete a focused HCM assessment before finalizing the shortlist. Document why the organization is changing, what must improve or not break, which processes need redesign, required integrations, data condition, and available internal capacity. The [SHRM guide to choosing a new HCM system](#) recommends grounding the search in business requirements and fit rather than treating every available capability as equally important. That distinction matters. A capability can be impressive and still have no value for your workforce.

Give the buying committee one page that answers:

- 1 Which measurable business outcomes must improve?
- 2 Which employee and manager moments cannot fail?
- 3 Which payroll, time, benefits, talent, and reporting rules create real complexity?
- 4 Which systems must exchange data with the HCM platform?
- 5 Who will make scope, process, security, and budget decisions?
- 6 Who will own the platform after implementation?

The 15-question HCM vendor selection checklist

1**Which business outcomes will this platform improve?**

Start with outcomes, not modules. Faster payroll close, fewer manual corrections, more reliable labor reporting, stronger manager self-service, simpler scheduling, better compliance controls, and a consistent employee experience are different goals.

Require each vendor to connect its proposed scope to the named outcomes. A generic feature tour does not prove fit.

2**Does the platform fit our workforce reality?**

Document employee populations, entities, locations, unions, job structures, schedules, seasonal peaks, mobile needs, and frontline access. A platform that fits professional services may fail a 24-hour manufacturing or healthcare operation.

Use sector-specific scenarios. A healthcare buyer might test credential visibility and differentials. A manufacturer might test shift changes and labor allocation. A retailer might test transfers, seasonal hiring, and manager approvals across locations.

3**Which processes should change instead of being recreated?**

Do not reproduce every legacy approval, spreadsheet, or workaround. Ask the vendor to distinguish configurable practice, required variation, and unnecessary complexity. This is where implementation planning begins.

4**Can the platform handle our hardest payroll and time scenarios?**

Do not settle for a standard employee moving through a standard pay cycle. Give vendors real scenarios involving retroactive pay, overtime, premiums, deductions, multiple assignments, leave, transfers, taxes, union rules, corrections, and off-cycle processing.

Require the workflow, calculation, exception, approval, audit trail, and reporting result. Payroll accuracy depends on the whole process.

5 How will data and integrations operate?

Map the systems that create or consume workforce data. For each connection, define the system of record, fields, frequency, trigger, error path, security requirement, and ongoing owner.

Ask vendors to explain connectors, files, APIs, middleware, monitoring, and recovery. A list of integrations is not an operating model. [Align HCM integration services](#) focus on keeping data trusted when records are rejected, delayed, or changed.

6 How does the vendor protect workforce data?

Bring security, privacy, legal, and IT leaders in early. Review identity controls, roles, encryption, logging, incident response, data location, subcontractors, backup, recovery, and secure development.

The [CISA Secure by Demand](#) guidance and the [NIST Privacy Framework](#) help buyers assess security and privacy governance. Treat them as procurement inputs, not post-contract details.

7 What implementation model are we actually buying?

Clarify what the software vendor, partner, and customer each own across discovery, configuration, data conversion, integrations, testing, training, change, cutover, and stabilization. Require named people and one responsibility matrix.

8 What does successful data conversion look like?

Ask each vendor to explain extraction, cleanup, mapping, transformation, mock loads, reconciliation, defect ownership, and final approval. Require written acceptance criteria for critical employee, payroll, benefit, balance, and security data.

9**What can reference customers prove?**

Speak with customers that resemble your workforce, geography, modules, integrations, and complexity. Ask what changed between the sales process and delivery, which work the customer underestimated, how issues escalated, and what ownership looked like after go-live.

10**What is the five-year total cost of ownership?**

Compare subscription, implementation, internal labor, integrations, testing, cleanup, training, change, support, reporting, releases, optimization, and administration. Normalize assumptions because a low first-year price can hide more customer-owned work.

11**Can leaders get the reporting they need?**

Bring real reports and decisions into the demo. Ask who builds each report, where fields originate, how definitions and security work, and how results reconcile. Score whether leaders can trust the output and act without rebuilding it in spreadsheets.

12**How will employees, managers, and administrators adopt it?**

Ask vendors to show the three to five tasks each role performs most. Observe steps, required knowledge, mobile use, accessibility, notifications, exceptions, and in-flow help.

Evaluate [role-based training](#), communications, manager preparation, champions, office hours, and reinforcement. Adoption is a workstream, not one session at the end.

13**What happens after go-live?**

Clarify support channels, severity levels, response targets, escalation, releases, administrator development, and optimization. Ask how implementation issues transfer into support and who owns the backlog. Review post-go-live support services before signing.

14**Which contract terms protect the outcome?**

Review service levels, escalation, staffing assumptions, change control, security commitments, renewal rules, price protections, implementation acceptance, and remedies with procurement and legal counsel. Commercial language should support the operating model presented during evaluation.

15**What happens if the relationship or platform no longer fits?**

Review renewals, price protections, service levels, data export, termination assistance, retention, deletion, integration portability, and

configuration documentation. A good vendor can explain how the partnership grows and how the customer remains in control.

A practical HCM vendor evaluation scorecard

Set weights before demos. The example below is a starting point, not a universal formula.

Evaluation area	Example weight	Evidence to score
Workforce and process fit	20%	Real scenarios, configuration approach, exceptions
Payroll, time, and compliance fit	15%	Calculations, controls, audit trail, edge cases
Data, integration, and reporting	15%	Architecture, ownership, monitoring, trusted outputs
Security, privacy, and resilience	10%	Controls, documentation, incident response, recovery
Implementation model and team	15%	Named people, responsibilities, assumptions, capacity
Adoption and user experience	10%	Role-based workflows, accessibility, training, change plan
Support and long-term ownership	10%	Service model, releases, administrator growth, optimization
Five-year commercial model	5%	Normalized total cost, terms, price risk, exit conditions

Score evidence, not enthusiasm. Require a written reason for every high or low score to resolve disagreements and preserve the decision logic.

How to run HCM demos that reveal fit

- 1 Send the same scenarios to every vendor.** Keep the comparison fair.
- 2 Limit generic company slides.** Protect time for real workflows and questions.
- 3 Use your terminology and rules.** Do not let a canned demo define the process.
- 4 Ask the proposed delivery team to participate.** Test the people as well as the product.
- 5 Record unanswered questions and follow-ups.** Do not convert promises into assumed capability.
- 6 Score independently before group discussion.** Reduce groupthink and seniority bias.
- 7 Run reference calls with similar customers.** Match workforce, geography, modules, and complexity.

HCM vendor selection red flags

- ◆ The vendor controls the agenda and avoids the buyer's scenarios.
- ◆ Product answers depend on future roadmap items without committed timing.
- ◆ The proposal does not separate vendor, partner, and customer responsibilities.
- ◆ Data cleanup, integrations, testing, and training are described as simple client tasks.
- ◆ Security or privacy questions are deferred until after selection.
- ◆ The delivery team is unnamed or unavailable during evaluation.
- ◆ Pricing cannot be normalized because assumptions and exclusions remain vague.
- ◆ References do not resemble the organization's workforce or complexity.

- ◆ The plan ends at go-live with no support or ownership transition.
- ◆ The contract makes data retrieval or exit assistance unclear.

How Align HCM helps

Align HCM is vendor agnostic. We help organizations define requirements, build scenarios and scorecards, compare implementation models, and pressure-test the work behind vendor promises. Start with the [Align HCM services overview](#) and client-side HCM project support. Platform-specific buyer guides can deepen the final review after a shortlist is credible, and the vendor-neutral decision model should come first.

Want a defensible process before demos or contracts move forward?

Ask Align HCM to run a vendor-neutral requirements and shortlist assessment. Free, and no obligation.

Talk to an Align HCM expert

Frequently asked questions

Q Who should be on an HCM vendor selection committee?

Include HR, payroll, finance, IT, security, operations, procurement, and an executive sponsor. Add benefits, talent, legal, or frontline leaders when needed. Give every participant a defined decision role.

Q How many HCM vendors should a company evaluate?

Evaluate enough vendors to compare credible alternatives without exhausting the team. A focused shortlist meeting non-negotiable needs is usually more useful than a large field receiving shallow demos.

Q What should an HCM request for proposal include?

Include outcomes, workforce profile, scope, scenarios, data and integrations, security and privacy, implementation responsibilities, internal capacity, adoption, support, commercial terms, and scoring. Require explicit assumptions, exclusions, dependencies, and roadmap items.

Q How should HCM vendors be scored?

Set weighted criteria before demos and score each vendor against the same scenarios. Include product fit, workforce complexity, data, security, implementation, adoption, support, cost, and ownership. Keep written rationale.

Q When should an independent HCM advisor join the process?

Bring an independent advisor in before requirements and shortlist decisions are fixed when market knowledge, implementation experience, capacity, or stakeholder agreement is limited. Earlier involvement creates more room to correct the process.

— EDITORIAL AND SEARCH BRIEF

EDITORIAL BRIEF

Search and conversion contract

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PERSONA

CHRO; CFO; HRIS leader; payroll leader; IT leader; procurement; executive sponsor

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HCM Vendor Selection Checklist: 15 Questions

PROVISIONAL SLUG

/blog/hcm-vendor-selection-checklist

META DESCRIPTION

Use this HCM vendor selection checklist to compare fit, payroll, data, security, implementation, adoption, support, cost, and long-term ownership.

CTA

Ask Align HCM to run a vendor-neutral HCM requirements and shortlist assessment.

SCHEMA RECOMMENDATION

Article plus FAQPage plus HowTo

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Author review: Maher El-Abdallah should approve all first-person language and experience-based statements before publication.

SOURCES

- [SHRM guide to choosing a new HCM system](#)
- [CISA Secure by Demand guide](#)
- [NIST Privacy Framework](#)
- [Align HCM services overview](#), assessments and strategic engagements, implementation services, and client-side services

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